

Abstract

This study examines the morphosyntactic behavior of Arabic lexical items in English-dominant speech among Arab American bilinguals. Based on original survey data from 22 participants between the ages of 16 and 32, the paper focuses on specific Arabic words, such as *yani*, *khalas*, and *ana*, in English conversations across informal and professional settings. The analysis shows that these lexical items function as free morphemes and are inserted without disrupting English syntax, often serving discourse, emotional, or identity-marking purposes. Grounded in sociolinguistic theory and Poplack's model of intra-sentential code-switching, this paper argues that code-switching among Arab Americans is intentional and structurally consistent. The findings indicate that language choices reflect bilingual fluency, cultural positioning, and adaptability within shifting social contexts. Ultimately, the paper contributes to a broader understanding of how language, identity, and social belonging intersect in bilingual communities while showing how Arabic keeps cultural resonance within hybrid linguistic environments.

1 Introduction

Code-switching is a typical linguistic behavior among bilingual speakers, referring to alternating between two languages within a single conversation or sentence. Earlier researchers viewed code-switching as a sign of linguistic weakness or interference in bilingual children. As Razem (2024) explains, "Since CS is a linguistic phenomenon that is considered a critical communication strategy occurring in language contact situations, some researchers have perceived it as a weakness or interference in bilingual children"(Grosjean, 2008; Wei, 2011). However, recent studies argue that it is a structured and fluent form of communication that follows grammatical rules. "Poplack (2015) contends that CS is not random; in fact, it is grammatically constrained and postulated three constraints: the equivalence, the morphological, and the size of constituents. For example, intra-sentential CS type involves a shift in language in the middle of a sentence, which suggests that the linguistic flow is without a pause or hesitation and requires the most fluency because it entails speakers to switch to the rules of syntax of the other language mid-thought or sentence" (Razem, 2024, p. 5). For Arab American bilinguals, switching between Arabic and English is a recurring process of interactions in social and professional settings that depends on the context, often reflecting the speaker's goals. For example, phrases such as "*Yallah*, let's go home" or "*Khalas*, I'm done talking" show how Arabic terms flow naturally within English sentence structures.

Reem Razem's (2024) autoethnographic study states that code-switching among Arabic-English bilinguals is a structured and meaningful communication strategy. Intra-sentential code-switching is when bilingual speakers often change between Arabic and English within a single sentence. For instance, an example of current research confirming high bilingual fluency and linguistic skills is Razem's document of her son saying, "*Ana kteer tired, biseer arouh anaam Mama? ... OK. Good night, habibti,*" which blends Arabic and English to express both emotional and cultural meaning. Poplack's theory explains that when bilinguals switch languages in a sentence, they technically still follow the grammatical rules of both languages, showing advanced proficiency.

Recent research supports the idea that bilingual speakers are purposeful in how they switch languages, according to Kais Sultan Mousa Alowidha (2024), who proves that code-switching is intentional since bilinguals choose which language to use based on the setting, topic, and who they're speaking to. Instead, he finds it a strategic and sophisticated communication tool used to navigate between different social roles, settings, and expressions of identity. For example, Alowidha notes that it is usual to find Arabs of the Gulf using a mixture of Arabic and English, or just English, and refers to the phenomenon of *Arabizi*, writing Arabic with English characters, as a standard technique among fluent, middle-class bilinguals. Alowidha uses Myers-Scotton's Markedness Model to explain that bilinguals switch languages to achieve goals.

Figure 1

Khalas, I'm done.

[Enough, I'm done]

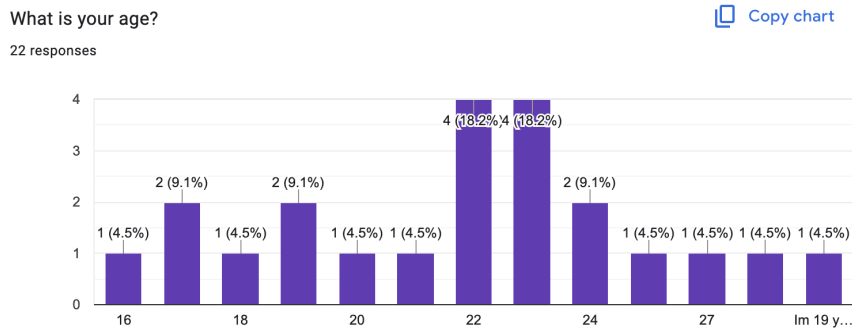
Example of Arabic lexical insertion in English speech

Khalas (enough) is used unaffectedly in an English sentence, showing how Arabic terms can be used without disrupting grammar or fluency.

Building on these studies, this paper offers a morphosyntactic analysis of how Arab American bilinguals use Arabic lexical items like *yani*, *khalas*, and *ana* in English-dominant sentences across social and professional settings. It focuses on general individuals, not a specific region, age group, or background. These words are inserted into English speech without experiencing morphological change. Speakers keep their fluency by smoothly combining the grammar of both languages.

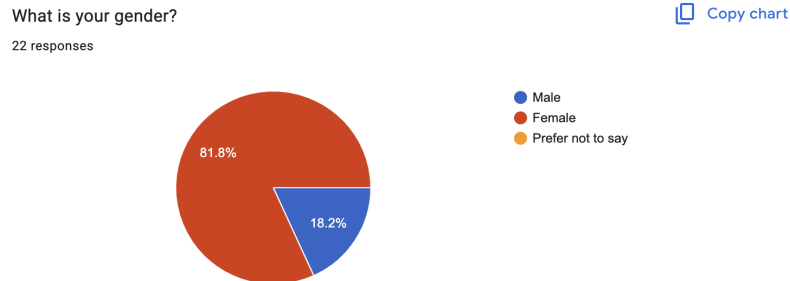
2 Data

Figure 2: Age distribution of survey participants ($N = 22$)



Participants included 22 Arab American bilinguals, ages 16 to 27, with the majority being 22 or 23.

Figure 3: Gender distribution of survey participants ($N = 22$)



Most respondents identified as female (81.8%), while 18.2% identified as male. No Participants selected “Prefer not to say.”

Informal Settings

Participants often reported switching languages casually in conversations with family and friends. According to the survey, 50% of respondents said they switch between Arabic and English “always” or “often” in informal conversations, while an additional 40.9% said they “sometimes” switch. This usage is shown in examples 1, 2, and 3 below:

1. *“Omg, wallah I didn’t know.”*
[Omg, I swear I didn’t know.]
2. *“Matcha is good for you, ya3ni it helps boost.”*
[Matcha is good for you, I mean it helps boost.]
3. *“Yallah, let’s get out of here. Khalas, it’s too much.”*
[Let’s go, it’s getting too much.]

Professional Settings

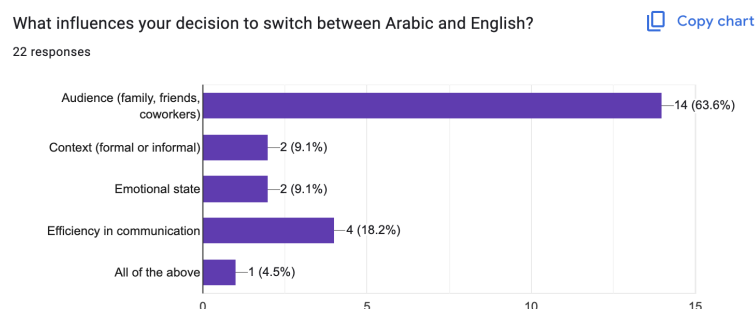
Participants used Arabic words strategically to navigate and influence their professional environments. Switching to Arabic allowed them to sound more in control, or they used Arabic to show they shared the same background with their Arabic-speaking coworkers. It also helped motivate others by using cultural expressions that carry emotional significance or urgency, such as “*yallah*” (let’s go) or “*khalas*” (enough/done), which can speed up decision-making and action. In fast-paced conversations, Arabic offered linguistic shortcuts or familiar phrasing that streamlined communication. Participants also utilized Arabic to share cultural ideas or jokes that didn’t work the same in English, which helped form a connection and show they had something in common. Finally, some switches were habitual. It wasn’t always on purpose, but it still added a flexible and natural way of speaking that worked well in a multilingual setting. Examples of this usage are provided in 4 and 5 below:

4. *“The project isn’t due until next week, ya3ni we still have some time left.”*
[The project isn’t due until next week, but I mean, we still have some time left.]

While this paper primarily focuses on the lexical items, *yani*, *khalas*, and *ana*, additional Arabic words such as *Insha’Allah* appeared in participant responses and demonstrate similar strategic use in professional contexts:

5. *“Insha’Allah, the new software will streamline our workflow.”*
[God willing, the new software will streamline our workflow.]

Figure 4: *Factors influencing Arabic-English code-switching decisions (N = 22)*



Finally, participants were asked what influences their decision to switch between Arabic and English. As shown in Figure 4, the majority (63.6%) identified the audience family, friends, or coworkers as the main factor. Other influences included efficiency in communication (18.2%), emotional state (9.1%), and context (9.1%). This supports the idea that code-switching is both linguistically structured and socially strategic, allowing bilingual speakers to adjust to different settings and relationships.

3 Syntactic Analysis

Although *yani*, *khalas*, and *ana* have different meanings, they maintain their original syntactic behavior across sentence contexts. Based on the survey observations, analyzing how these lexical items preserve their morphosyntactic roles from Arabic when used in English-dominant settings is possible. These Arabic words are free morphemes that function as discourse markers, adverbials, or subject pronouns within English sentence structures. They maintain their original morphological form and integrate into English syntax without requiring inflection or structural adjustment. To support this proposal, I analyzed sample sentences that indicate how these words commonly appear in bilingual speech. Consider the following examples.

6. *Yani* (يعني)

Example 1: “*I couldn’t believe she said that, yani; why would you say that?*”

[Translation: I couldn’t believe she said that, I mean, why would you say that?]

In this sentence, *yani* is a free morpheme that is a discourse marker that keeps its original morphological form and appears mid-sentence as a syntactically optional adverbial. Structurally, it behaves like English equivalents, such as *I mean* or *you know*, to clarify or emphasize. Its use demonstrates how bilingual speakers insert Arabic lexical items into English sentence structures without violating word order or syntactic rules.

7. *Khalas* (خلاص)

Example 2: “*Khalas, I’m not going to care.*”

[Enough, I’m not going to care.]

Khalas functions as a sentence-initial adverbial expressing emotional finality while retaining its original form. It is inserted without affecting English word order to show that Arabic lexical items can emphasize tone while fitting syntactically into English speech.

8. *Ana* (أنا)

Example 3: “*Yani ana, what am I supposed to do?*”

[I mean, me, what am I supposed to do?]

This sentence uses *ana* as a subject pronoun alongside its English equivalent for emphasis. It remains unchanged in form and fits naturally within the English sentence, showing how Arabic pronouns can be used for identity marking without disrupting syntactic structure.

4 Discussion and Conclusion

In this paper, I propose that Arabic words like *yani*, *khalas*, and *ana* are used in English sentences without modifying form or disrupting the structure that initially follows English and Arabic grammatical rules. Participants code-switched naturally in informal and professional settings, often without hesitation, showing how common and natural these words are in everyday bilingual speech. While this paper focused on those specific words, other terminology of Arabic words like *wallah* and *Insha’Allah* also appeared in responses. Though they weren’t the center of this analysis, their presence suggests that everyday bilingual speech includes Arabic expressions tied to culture and emotion. This shows that code-switching isn’t just about filling a linguistic gap; it’s also about communicating emotion, identity, and belonging.

There are some remaining questions. One is whether participants code-switch as frequently in professional settings because they work in Arabic-English bilingual environments. I didn’t have participants specify the language used in their workplace, and even though I know most of them personally, I can’t identify what kind of environments they work in. According to the survey, 45.5% of participants said they sometimes switch between Arabic and English in professional settings, and 40.9% said the same in social settings. Switching isn’t regular, but it is enough to show that Arabic use is acceptable in both settings. However, this would be different if participants worked in more English-dominant environments.

If Arabic wasn't understood or welcomed in the workplace, I imagine people would switch much less, maybe only in private conversations, or not at all. Sometimes, they might avoid using Arabic altogether out of fear of being judged, misunderstood, or even discriminated against. The comfort of switching languages greatly varies depending on whether the environment makes room for both.

Overall, this study shows how Arab American bilinguals use Arabic words in English sentences without changing the structure or meaning. Switching between languages shows how speakers manage tone, adjust to who they're talking to, and respond to different situations. Future research could study how things like region, job, or age might shape these patterns, especially in places where Arabic isn't usually spoken or understood.

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